SESSION 1 PRESENTATION

Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Age

Tale 1: Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* (1864)

Scott Axelrod

SESSION 1 · TODAY

What we'll cover

Context of Notes from Underground	Slides 3–4, PDF 3-5
Clip 1 and Concrete Questions	Slides 5–6, PDF 6-7
A Dialog About Notes	Slides 7–11, PDF 8--12
Abstract Questions	Slide 12, PDF 13-14
Toward 1984: Legacy, Cartoon Summary, Arc, and Lenses	Slides 13–16, PDF 15-18

Russia under Alexander II, 1855–1881

Establishment

1855

Alexander II takes the throne

- Autocrat over an empire of serfs
- Soon launches the Great Reforms

Loosens, then cracks down

1861

Serfs freed; censorship loosened

- Reforms make room for radicals
- Radicals want more; the government cracks down

Disestablishment

1863

Chernyshevsky's What Is to Be Done?

- Nihilists trust only science and reason
- Know your true interest and you'll be good
- The Crystal Palace: society designed by reason

Crystal Palace: from the novella; not in the show

Anti-disestablishment?

1864

Dostoevsky's Notes from Underground

- We are not piano keys
- Against reason claiming totality

The stone wall ▸

Establishment shaken

1881

Alexander II assassinated

- Killed by the People's Will
- Weeks after Dostoevsky's death

Russia under Alexander II, 1855–1881

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Crystal Palace: from the novella; not in the show

The impossible means the stone wall! What stone wall? Why, of course, the laws of nature, the deductions of natural science, mathematics. As soon as they prove to you, for instance, that you are descended from a monkey, then it is no use scowling, accept it for a fact. When they prove to you that in reality one drop of your own fat must be dearer to you than a hundred thousand of your fellow-creatures, and that this conclusion is the final solution of all so-called virtues and duties and all such prejudices and fancies, then you have just to accept it, there is no help for it, for twice two is a law of mathematics. Just try refuting it.

Notes from Underground, Part I, ch. 3 (Garnett translation)

From the novella; not in Larry Cedar's show · click to close

Two writers, two Siberias, in opposite order

Dostoevsky

1849	Joins a utopian-socialist circle
Punished	Mock execution, Siberia, exile
1864	Writes Notes from Underground

Punished first, then writes

Chernyshevsky

1863	Writes What Is to Be Done? in prison
Punished	Civil execution, Siberia, exile
Legacy	Inspires anti-tsarist radicals

Writes first, then is punished

CLIP 1 · BACK INTO THE SHOW

Larry Cedar as the Underground Man



"I am a sick man.... I am a spiteful man."

Watch from 1:30

Notes from Underground, one-man show, Garnett translation · youtube.com/watch?v=asp5tqDql0g

Concrete questions about the Underground Man

1 What is his situation?

2 How did he get into it?

3 What was his dilemma?

4 What about his personality might have caused him difficulty?

The protagonist is never named; by convention he is called the Underground Man.

"I am a sick man.... I am a spiteful man."



Not piano keys

We'll act against our own interest just to prove we're free.

Watch from 17:58-19:00

✓*In the show*



2 × 2 = 4

"Twice two makes four" is the beginning of death.

From the novella; left out of the show



No tongue allowed

In the Crystal Palace you can't even stick out your tongue.

From the novella; left out of the show

The target is not reason itself. It is reason claiming totality.

Not the Keys of a Piano

AVERY "I am a sick man. I am a spiteful man." That's how Dostoevsky's Notes from Underground begins.

RILEY Not exactly a warm welcome.

AVERY He doesn't want one. He's a retired clerk who has spent forty years in his corner, and he tells us that to be too conscious is an illness.

RILEY An illness? Most of us think knowing ourselves is the cure.

AVERY Not for him. He sees through every motive, including his own, so he can't become anything. Not spiteful, not kind, not a hero, not even an insect.

RILEY So what's he arguing against?

AVERY The confident people who say we only do nasty things because we don't know our own interests. Show us our real advantage, they say, and we'll be good out of sheer necessity.

RILEY That sounds reasonable.

Not the Keys of a Piano

AVERY That's exactly his target. He says what a person wants is simply independent choice, whatever that independence may cost and wherever it may lead.

RILEY Even if the choice is stupid?

AVERY Especially then. A man may choose something stupid just to keep the right to choose it. Otherwise, he says, we'd be nothing but the keys of a piano.

RILEY Press the key, and the note sounds.

AVERY And he asks the reformers a question: how do you know it's even desirable to reform people that way?

RILEY But he's hardly a hero of freedom.

AVERY No, and the second half shows it. He meets Liza, a young woman in a brothel, and gives her a moving speech about the life she could still have. He gives her his address.

RILEY And she comes.

Not the Keys of a Piano

AVERY She does. And he turns on her. He tells her it was all a game, that power was what he wanted. Then he breaks down and says, "I can't be good."

RILEY So he can stand up to the reformers, but he can't accept one person's kindness.

AVERY He even admits that, for him, loving meant showing his moral superiority.

RILEY And how does he leave us?

AVERY He turns the mirror on us. Give any one of us a little more independence, he says, relax the control, and we'd be begging to be under control again at once.

RILEY That's chilling.

AVERY It's why this is a good place to start thinking about defiance and control. He sees the danger of being managed for our own good. But he also suspects we might want it.

RILEY Then the question is whether we can choose freely without ending up alone in his corner.

AVERY Or whether we'd even notice we'd stopped choosing.

CLIP 2 · AFTER THE DIALOGUE

How he leaves us



Give us a little more independence, relax the control, and we'd be begging to be under control again at once.

Watch from 1:29:45

Avery's paraphrase of the closing pages, from the dialogue

QUESTIONS · MORE ABSTRACT / SUBJECTIVE

Through the lens of human outlier analysis

How is the protagonist unusual in the society in which he lives, and how is he trying to influence that society?

Do you sympathize with the protagonist and his plight? What about the other characters?

Can we usefully separate out the dysfunction from the creative insight?

What does the protagonist see about society that those around him do not see?

THE LENS

Human Outlier Analysis

Foucault, Madness and Civilization (1961): the Age of Reason built institutions to cast radical thinkers out as mad or criminal.

Do we lose something if we dismiss him as mad?

A modern reading ▸

These also appear under Tale 1 in the Preface to the course.

QUESTIONS · MORE ABSTRACT / SUBJECTIVE

Through the lens of human outlier analysis

His self-awareness of his own flaws clashes with his desire for autonomy, creating a dynamic tension that mirrors our modern struggle for identity in a world that increasingly oscillates between demanding conformity and celebrating radical individualism. This struggle for self-acceptance amidst a perceived hostile world remains one of Dostoevsky's most profound and unsettling insights into the human condition.

Man is condemned to be free; because once thrown into the world, he is responsible for everything he does.

Jean-Paul Sartre, Existentialism Is a Humanism (1946), highlighted in the article

Sartre's words resonate deeply with the Underground Man's predicament. He is free, but this freedom is a heavy burden, compelling him to confront his choices and their consequences without external validation. He chooses self-sabotage, spite, and isolation not because they are rational, but precisely because they are his own choices, asserting his will against a deterministic universe. This is Dostoevsky's synthesis: acknowledging that human nature is fundamentally complex, contradictory, and often irrational, and that our greatest freedom lies in embracing—or rejecting—this uncomfortable truth.

"The Death of the Rational Man," The Third Citizen (Substack), Sep 13, 2025

click to close

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What came after: a literary line and a violent one

The literary line: engineering human behavior

1864
Notes from Underground
Later adopted as a forerunner of existentialism

1920–21
Zamyatin, We
Glass apartments; citizens reduced to numbers

1932
Huxley, Brave New World
Lessons whispered before birth

1949
Orwell, 1984
Our next tale

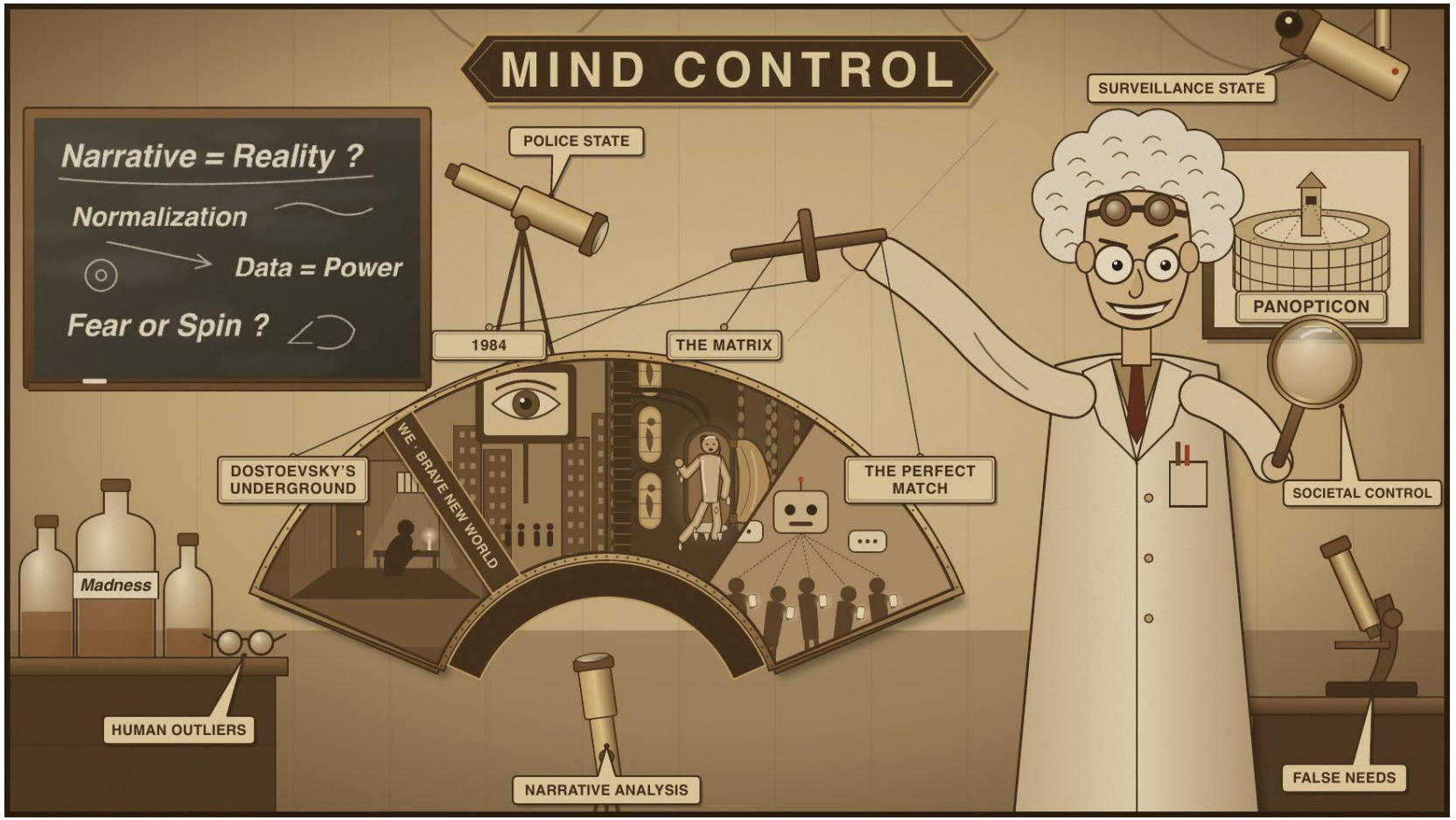
The violent line: from ideas to terror

1866 Karakozov, influenced by Chernyshevsky's novel, tries to kill the Tsar

1872 Dostoevsky's Demons depicts nihilism turning into terror

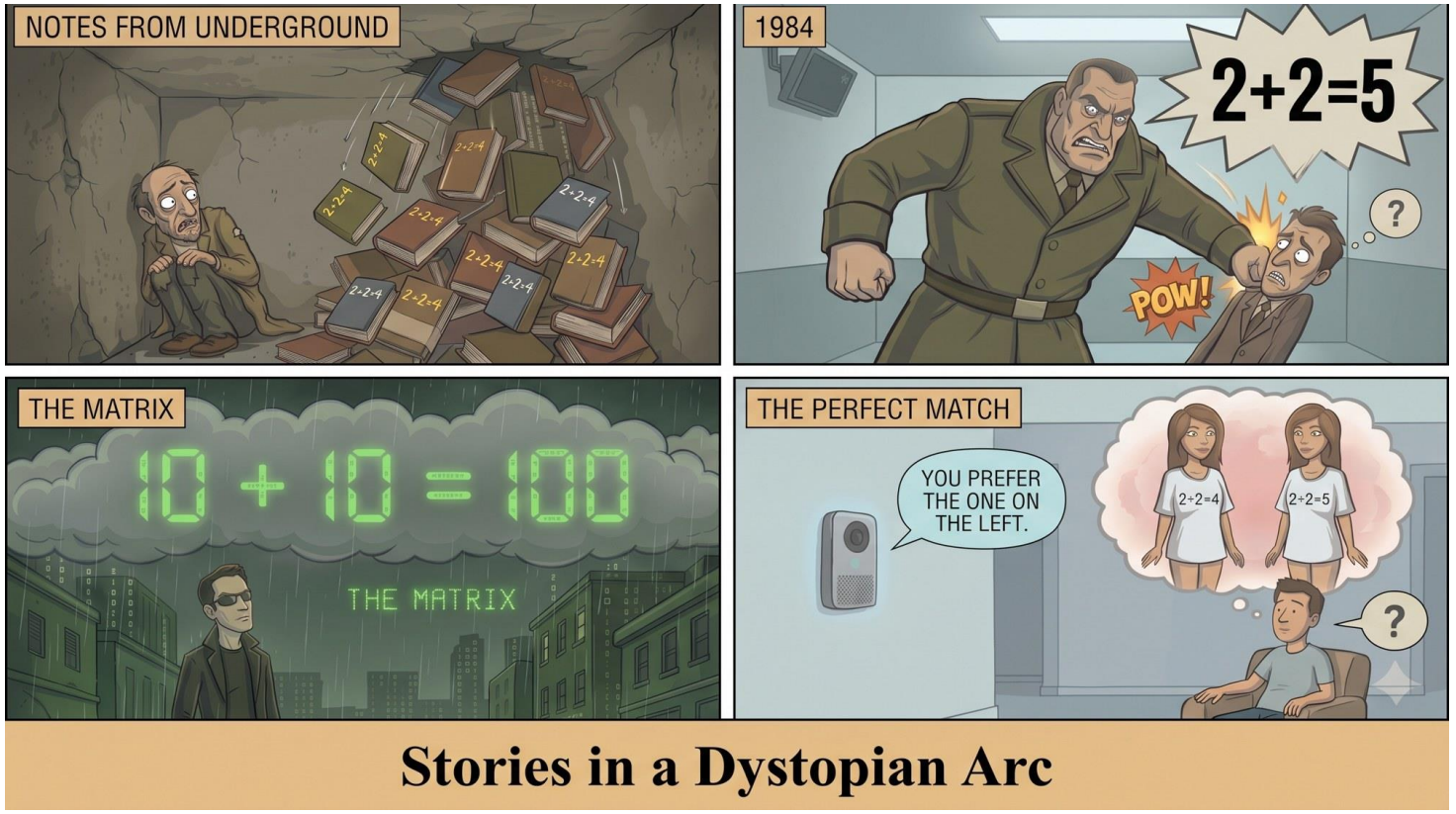
1881 People's Will assassinates Alexander II

Course overview



- Look at modern-age stories where societies impose or offer mind control.
- Consider characters who are rebelling.
- Ask questions through various lenses.

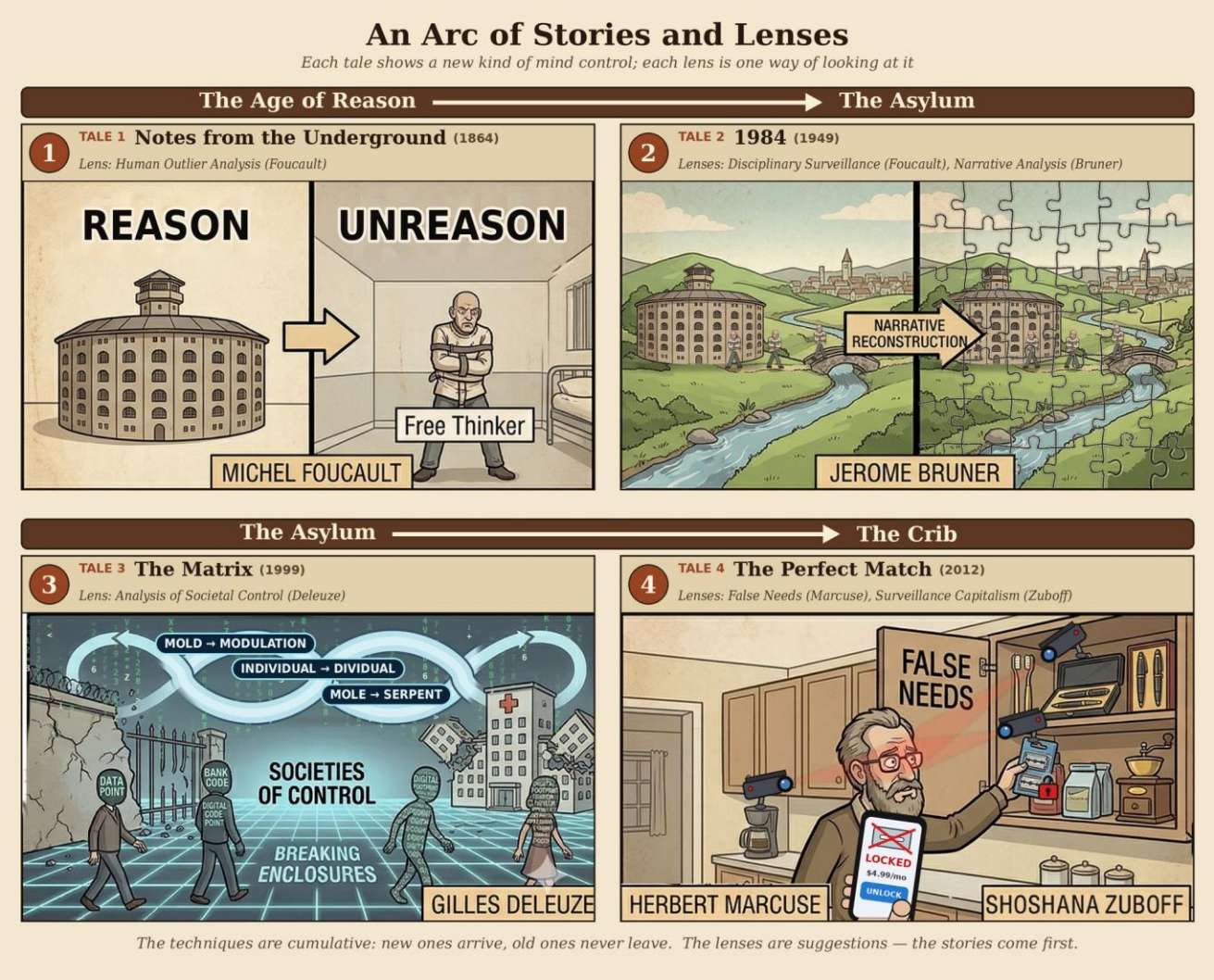
Stories in a dystopian arc



- **Dostoevsky's Underground Man,** isolated and crushed by 2 + 2 = 4 reason.
- **Winston (1984),** pounded by Big Brother to truly believe 2 + 2 = 5.
- **Neo (The Matrix),** perceiving his whole world is a simulation, seeing 2 + 2 = 4 in binary.
- **Sai (The Perfect Match),** nudged by the AI agent Tilly into preferring the beautiful girl in the "2 + 2 = 4" T-shirt.

The 2 + 2 = 4 image comes from the novella. Larry Cedar's show leaves it out, so this panel is our summary of the book, not of the performance.

Some lenses



- **Human Outlier Analysis** (Michel Foucault)
  - Madness and confinement
  - Knowledge and limits of thought
  - Panopticism and disciplinary surveillance
- **Narrative Analysis** (Jerome Bruner)
- **Societal Control** (Gilles Deleuze)
  - Foucault's "enclosures" (prisons, schools, hospitals) are breaking down.
  - We are "dividuals": data points, bank codes, digital footprints tracked in a continuous loop.
  - Not a cage, but a network where control is fluid and constant.
- **False Needs** (Herbert Marcuse)
- **Surveillance Capitalism** (Shoshana Zuboff)